

Teknika

Narrative Design Document · firststef

Theme:

I believe that knowledge comes with a price because once you discover something, the world changes forever.

Pillars of Fantasy:

1. I want the player to feel the intellectual thrill and curiosity of being an investigative wizard uncovering ancient secrets.
2. I want the player to feel the creeping dread of realizing a seemingly harmless discovery can do a lot of damage to society.
3. I want the player to experience the heavy burden of consequence when their discoveries permanently change the world around them.

Plot: You are a corporate magical wizard, your job is discovering magic, and you slowly realize your discoveries have a greater impact on the world than you expect.

This sequence focuses on the **intellectual thrill** of the core loop, the **creeping dread** of corporate oversight, and the **heavy burden** of seeing the world change permanently due to the wizard's research.

1. A corporate wizard meticulously combines ancient runes to unlock the secrets of a seemingly harmless artifact because they are driven by the **intellectual thrill** of uncovering the lost history of a fallen civilization.
2. Because they are required to **publish their research** for their corporate monitors, they feel a fleeting sense of reward as their discoveries are immediately converted into new "efficiency" tools for the public.
3. The wizard begins to feel a **creeping dread** because they observe that their "efficiency" runes are being used to strip-mine the natural world, realizing their harmless discovery has been weaponized for systemic damage.
4. Because the corporation realizes the wizard's growing hesitation, they increase their monitoring and demand one final, "unretractable" discovery that promises infinite magical energy.
5. Despite the **heavy burden of consequence**, the wizard finalized the research because they believed they could control the outcome, only to watch as the final rune permanently alters the laws of physics across the globe.

6. Because the world has now changed forever, the wizard is left to wander a transformed landscape, serving as a living testament to the belief that **knowledge always comes with a price**

Core loop:

action: you research magical artifacts left by an ancient civilization: you choose which aspect of the artifact you want to discover (seemingly similar aspects but very different) -
> you combine magical runes to achieve it.

Or you choose "how" you approach the discovery - brute force or careful observation.

reward: -> you unlock that research, which gives you new runes, new tools, etc.

progression: -> you are monitored and have to publish your research, and you observe that your research has had vast impact on the world you live in

repeat: -> you again go to work the next day and research the magical artifacts

Narrative Spaces:

Runes and Magic System: Descriptions of the runes and the "how" of combining them, which provides the intellectual thrill and the technical framework for the discoveries.

Artifact Lore: The history of the ancient civilization, providing clues about why they fell and foreshadowing the dread the player will feel.

Published Research Logs: A space where the player sees the "vast impact" of their work through corporate reports and public observations, illustrating the burden of consequence.

Adversary/Monitor Dialogue: Communications from the corporate monitors that pressure the player to continue their research despite the visible damage to society.

Worldbuilding:

The story is taking place in the city of Teknika, a city of great invention and science, yet, a new rumour has reached the headlines: magic might actually be real, and it is being researched.

The story takes place in a rather tumultuous time, where resources like oil and electricity are becoming expensive, and so, a wonder has it, a renowned interest in magic has arisen.

I want the player to feel that sense of wonder about something unexplainable, new and different from all the way the world worked before he learned about magic.

The people of Teknika have seen it all, from wonders of nuclear energy, to wars, to psychological warfare, AI, every piece of technology is already old news. Yet, they never thought possible that magic was actually real.

Lore: Magic is actually not created to be useful. It is created to express everything. Yet the corporation will try to force it to have a utility function.

The corporation, working class, middle class citizens, elite class citizens, military, the hidden magical society, the player.

A much more advanced society, yet pretty much like ours, in the sense that politics are still exhausting, corruption still exists, poverty, declining meaning, etc.

Environment

- The lab: an advanced laboratory with all the tools you need to understand the mysterious magic.
- The (decaying) city: as the plot progresses, the environment outside the lab should show the “price” of magic. Contrast the cleanliness and high-tech lab with the dirty, chaotic streets of the city.

Rules of setting:

- The Rule of Irreversibility: Once a magical discovery is "published" to the corporate monitors, it is unretractable. The world state updates permanently, and the player cannot "undo" the societal shift caused by their research (even when they try to reverse it, they only make it worse).
- The Utility Constraint: Magic in Teknika is inherently expressive, but the corporate setting forces it into a utility function (e.g., solving the energy crisis). This creates tension when the player realizes they are forcing a chaotic force into a rigid system.

Emotional Evocation of Existing Elements:

- **Ancient Runes:** These should evoke **awe and mystery** initially, but as the player combines them, the sensory descriptions should shift—for instance, footsteps "echoing" differently or the air humming unpleasantly—to evoke **creeping dread**.
- **Teknika's Architecture:** Use "boxy skyscrapers and gray facades" to evoke the cold, uncaring nature of the corporation, making the "magical discoveries" feel even more like a dangerous disruption.
- **The "Published Research" Logs:** These should shift from feeling like a **reward** (new tools/runes) to a **burden** (seeing reports of how your work "weaponized" the natural world).

Setting Sketch: Turning World Elements into a Setting

- **Element: The Magic Artifacts:** They start appearing simple to understand, but soon you discover that they behave in weird ways and not at all as they are expected to work, always bringing a surprise.
- **Element: The Resource Crisis:** As the player provides "infinite magical energy," the city's reliance on oil and electricity should vanish, replaced by something stranger. The "peaceful" science of the start should be replaced by a world that no longer follows the laws of physics
- **Element: Corporate Monitors:** Their dialogue should change from supportive and rewarding to demanding and threatening as they realize the "unretractable" power the player is uncovering

Characters:

1. Drivers (Plot Movers)

- **Dr. Aris Vance, The Corporate Wizard (Player Avatar/Protagonist): A researcher in an advanced laboratory tasked with uncovering the secrets of magic.**
- **Role in Game & Story:** The anchor of the core loop. They research artifacts, combine runes, and publish their findings, driving the permanent changes in the world.
- **Goal:** To research magical artifacts left by an ancient civilization and uncover their secrets.
- **Motivation:** Initially driven by the intellectual thrill and curiosity of uncovering lost history.
- **Ethos:** Methodical and analytical. They start with a naive scientific pursuit, but their ethos shifts toward creeping dread and guilt as they realize the heavy burden of their consequences.
- **Director Silas Croft, The Corporate Monitor (Antagonist): The overarching corporate entity and the wizard's direct overseer.**
- **Role in Game & Story:** They pressure the player, demand published research, and actively weaponize the player's discoveries to strip-mine the natural world.
- **Goal:** To force inherently expressive magic into a rigid utility function to solve Teknika's energy/resource crisis.
- **Motivation:** Boundless profit, efficiency, and maintaining control over the declining city of Teknika.
- **Ethos:** Cold and fake. They view ancient magic purely as a commodity and disregard any "irreversible" damage to society.

2. Passengers (Supporters & Allies)

- **Kaelen the Keeper, The Hidden Magical Society Emissary (Guardian/Reason): A member of the underground faction mentioned in the worldbuilding lore.**
- Role in Game: Serves as the voice of warning. They provide context on the Artifact Lore and the true, expressive nature of magic.
- Goal: To preserve magic's true expressive form and prevent Teknika's destruction.
- Motivation: Reverence for the fallen ancient civilization that originally created the artifacts.
- Ethos: Traditional, cautious, and deeply respectful of the unknown. They highlight the danger of the "brute force" research methods.
- **Jada Ryes, The Working Class Contact (Emotion): A citizen living in the decaying streets of Teknika outside the sterile lab.**
- Role in Game: They are the player's window into the "vast impact" of their research. Through dialogue, they show how the newly published "efficiency" tools are actually harming everyday people.
- Goal: To survive the chaotic shifts in the city's economy and physical laws.
- Motivation: Protecting their family/community from the fallout of the corporation's greed.
- Ethos: Pragmatic, grounded, and desperate. They contrast the high-minded intellectual thrill of the lab with the harsh reality of the streets.
- Having dark humour, simple language, maybe very wise, they see through lies.

3. Episodic Characters

- **Military Liaisons & Elite Citizens:**
- Role in Game: They appear periodically as the player unlocks specific tiers of research. For example, a Military Liaison appears to take control of a specific rune combination, demonstrating exactly how a seemingly harmless discovery has been weaponized.

4. Extras

- **The Citizens of Teknika (Working, Middle, Elite classes):**
- Role in Game: Background characters seen through the "Published Research Logs" or visually in the decaying city. They exist to reflect the "Rule of Irreversibility," showing how the world updates permanently based on the player's actions.

Character Spec Document: Dr. Aris Vance (The Corporate Wizard)

Overview

Dr. Aris Vance is the player's avatar. They work in a high-tech lab in the city of Teknika, researching newly discovered magic.

- Goal: Research artifacts and publish findings to the corporation.
- Motivation: The intellectual thrill of discovery.
- Ethos: Scientific curiosity that slowly morphs into the heavy burden of consequence.

Their character arc moves from the excitement of scientific discovery to the creeping dread of seeing their work permanently and negatively alter the world.

For the Art Team (Visuals & Animation)

- Base Design: Visuals should reflect a blend of high-tech corporate sterility and ancient mystery. A clean, advanced lab coat, but perhaps their hands are stained with glowing, unpredictable magical residue.
- Progression Design: As the plot progresses and the "Rule of Irreversibility" takes effect, Aris's appearance should degrade. The clean lab coat becomes frayed; the sterile workspace becomes cluttered with chaotic, glowing runes that defy the city's traditional physics.
- Animations:
- Researching (Action): Two distinct animation sets needed based on player choice: "Brute Force" (aggressive, mechanical manipulation of the artifact) vs. "Careful Observation" (delicate, hesitant studying).
- Combining Runes: A fluid, intellectual animation, like a master clockmaker or a hacker compiling code.
- Publishing: A heavy, reluctant animation of submitting the data to Director Croft and the Corporate Monitors, emphasizing the dread of the action.

For the Production Team (Tasks & Scope)

- Priority: Highest. This is the main lens through which the player experiences the narrative.
- Assets Required: * 1 Base 3D Model / 2D Sprite for the lab environment.
- UI elements tied directly to the character: The "Rune Combination Interface" and the "Published Research Logs" terminal.
- UI Portraits for dialogue with Director Croft and Jada Ryes, showing a progression from excited to exhausted/dread-filled.

For the Game Design Team (Usage & Mechanics)

- **Core Loop Role:** Aris is the sole operator of the research mechanics. They do not engage in traditional combat.
- **Mechanics Focus:** The player uses Aris to select aspects of an artifact, choose the approach (brute force vs. observation), and combine runes.
- **Tension Anchor:** The character is the vessel for the game's tension: balancing the reward of unlocking new tools against the narrative punishment of the Corporation weaponizing those tools.

For the Development Team (Code & Implementation)

- **The Rule of Irreversibility:** The core system tied to this character. When the player clicks "Publish Research," the game state must permanently update. Build a robust save/state system where these choices cannot be undone, reflecting the thematic burden.
- **Rune System:** Implement the UI logic for combining runes and unlocking new branches of the research tree.
- **Dialogue Triggers:** Code triggers so that after a piece of research is published, Director Croft's dialogue aggressively updates, demanding the next, more dangerous discovery.

Narrative sequence:

1. Keep working on your game (adding and polishing all the elements you need)
2. Decide on your narrative structure and strategy (how do you want to tell a story and how do you connect it to the gameplay)

Narrative x Gameplay Specification: "Teknika"

Plot & Narrative Structure Overview

- **Theme:** Knowledge comes with a price, and once a discovery is made, the world changes forever.
- **Structure Type:** Iterative Descent / Escalating Consequence Structure. The narrative loop mirrors the daily corporate grind, escalating in stakes and environmental decay with each cycle.
- **Narrative Strategy:** The story is driven by the "Rule of Irreversibility." Publishing research permanently updates the world state, turning the player's mechanical progression into a heavy narrative burden.

Sequence 1: The Spark of Utility (Intro)

Episode 1: The First Rune

Dr. Vance, a corporate wizard, discovers a strange resonance in a dormant artifact. In a pristine, sterile lab, the player learns the core puzzle mechanics by combining two basic runes to create a perpetual light source. It feels like an innocent, brilliant discovery. The player clicks "Publish Research" for the first time. Director Silas Croft immediately sends a congratulatory message, and the player is rewarded with new tools, establishing the positive reinforcement loop.

Sequence 2: The Corporate Mandate

Episode 2: Quotas and Consequences

Vance learns their "perpetual light" has been weaponized as a limitless heat-ray for corporate strip-mining. Croft demands faster results and higher efficiency. The player is tasked with uncovering a kinetic propulsion rune. During this episode, the puzzles become more complex. Once published, the lab receives a sleek, high-tech visual upgrade, but ambient dialogue from passing scientists hints at severe ecological damage outside the building.

Sequence 3: Creeping Dread

Episode 3: The Attrition Engine

The corporation demands a self-replicating energy loop. Vance must combine runes of harvest and motion. Gameplay introduces "volatile" runes that can damage the workspace if mishandled. Jada Ryes, a junior researcher, sneaks into the lab and begs Vance to stop the research, warning that the tectonic plates are destabilizing. The player tries to cancel the research, but the corporate UI overrides their input, forcing them to publish to progress the game.

Episode 4: Echoes in the Code

The world state visibly degrades. Through the lab window, the sky turns a sickly, smoggy purple, and the sterile lab lights begin to flicker and fail. Vance attempts to use the mechanics to secretly research a neutralizing rune—something to undo the damage—but the corporate monitors actively deploy countermeasures, adding a stealth/hacking element to the puzzle interface. The artifact begins to glow ominously, physically reacting to the damage being done to the world outside. Inevitably his attempt fails and he makes a bigger mess.

Sequence 4: The Ultimatum (Climax)

Episode 5: The Director's Demand

The corporation is losing control of the kinetic anomalies tearing the city apart. Croft appears via a massive, imposing hologram, locking down the lab. He demands Vance synthesize a 'Master Binding' rune to enslave the rogue magic. Vance realizes this will permanently alter the fundamental laws of physics. The player faces the most difficult, multi-stage puzzle of the game, fighting against a strict countdown timer and alarms blaring in the background.

Episode 6: The Point of No Return

Vance successfully builds the Master Binding. The player is given a final choice to hit "Publish" or "Destroy." However, if they choose destroy, Croft's override protocols kick in. The system forcefully publishes the data. The artifact violently shatters on the desk, sending a reality-warping shockwave through the building. The game's UI corrupts and fragments, cementing the "Rule of Irreversibility."

Sequence 5: Aftermath

Episode 7: The Ash of Discovery

The pristine corporate lab is in ruins, with the walls torn away to reveal the outside world. Vance steps out into a permanently transformed landscape where gravity is fractured and the sky is shattered into geometric shards. The player controls Vance walking through the ruins, seeing the physical manifestation of their "efficiency" runes tearing the environment apart. The game concludes as Vance finds a new, heavily mutated artifact pulsing in the rubble, proving that the cycle of discovery and consequence is eternal.

The Narrative x Gameplay Implementation Strategy

(For the Game Design & Development Teams)

The Core Loop vs. The Narrative Flow The tension of the game relies entirely on balancing the intellectual thrill of the core puzzle mechanics against the narrative punishment of the corporation weaponizing those tools.

- Action (Research & Methodology): * Players select aspects of an artifact and choose their approach: *Brute Force* (aggressive, mechanical manipulation) or *Careful Observation* (delicate, hesitant studying).
- Implementation: These choices must trigger distinct animation sets for Dr. Vance and influence how the runes react.
- Progression (The Rule of Irreversibility): * Once a magical discovery is published to the corporate monitors, it is unretractable.
- Implementation: The development team must build a robust save/state system. When the player clicks "Publish Research," the game state permanently updates and cannot

be undone.

- World & Character Degradation: * The environment outside the lab should show the “price” of magic as the city decays.
- Implementation: Dr. Vance's clean lab coat must become frayed, and the UI portraits for dialogue (with Director Croft and Jada Ryes) must show a visual progression from excited to dread-filled and exhausted.

Technical writing:

Portfolio Piece 2: Teknika — Corporate Wizard Research Game

- Context: *Teknika* is a puzzle-narrative game (5 sequences / 7 episodes) where a corporate researcher weaponizes ancient magic.
- Problem: The core theme focuses on the weight of irreversible knowledge. Players needed to feel this mechanically, ensuring that "doing well" at the puzzles actively escalated the narrative dread.
- Role: Sole Narrative Designer. Owned theme, plot, world rules, character briefs, and narrative×gameplay implementation specs.
- Decision: Implemented the "Rule of Irreversibility" as a hard system constraint. Clicking "Publish Research" permanently locks the save-state. Early successes yield rewards, but later publishes visibly degrade the city UI, corrupt character portraits, and lock out player agency. This gave developers and artists a clear visual progression pipeline tied strictly to game states.
- Outcome: Engineered an irreversible state system that transformed standard puzzle progression into an escalating moral trap, embedding the theme directly into the core gameplay loop.

Considering that i come from gamedev background...

I showed the consequences of the discovery through the environmental storytelling.